that “the two countries should arrive at a firm understanding which will involve a programme of cooperation, coordination and even structural inter-relation of strategy, tactics between the Soviet and Indian defence forces against a possible Chinese involvement in a conflict with [India] or the Soviet Union.” Dhar, however, had demurred, saying that the two countries did not need to be “thinking in terms of any military alliance” since the treaty already provided for consultations.[278] Grechko had persisted, noting the potential benefits to India of “some form of a military alliance” with the Soviet Union. When Manekshaw said that India needed equipment to be prepared against China, Grechko had replied that if they had an alliance he would “earmark 50 ICBMs for [India’s] defence against China.”[279] India, however, had remained reticent.

The concern about overdependence was also why, as Keating noted, “India does not wish to close off indefinitely this [US] relationship and option.” These concerns came to the fore as India—like China—watched warily as Soviet leaders met with their American counterparts in Moscow that summer. Concerned about détente at India’s expense, Gandhi and her foreign minister warned both superpowers about trying to carve out spheres of influence in South Asia.[280] Her government also continued to show little enthusiasm for Brezhnev’s collective security system. Soviet officials brought it up again in March, and then in June claimed that the Indo-Soviet treaty was among the first steps toward such a system. Some in the Congress Party had suggested signing on to the Brezhnev plan.[281] The government, however, asserted that it had not received any such proposal from Moscow and that the superpowers should leave Asians to sort out their own affairs.[282]

Reducing Dependence

India’s desire to decrease its overall dependence also continued, causing Gandhi to seek better Sino-Indian relations. Just after the war, Swaran Singh had indicated that India would continue to seek improved relations with China. Two months later—and just before Nixon’s China visit—Gandhi had publicly said that India “would like normal relations with China.” She had pointed out that Sino-Indian relations were no worse than before.[283] A Congress Party resolution on international affairs that summer especially mentioned China as one of the countries with which India wanted